

SpectrumReady Digital Guide

5 Programs Every Autism Parent Must Know About

The Free Guide That Could Change Your Family's Financial Future

FREE

SpectrumReady

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Important Notice — Please Read Before Proceeding

Educational Information Only. This guide is for general informational and educational purposes only. It does not constitute legal, financial, or medical advice. The information in this guide is not a substitute for advice from a licensed attorney, financial advisor, healthcare provider, or other qualified professional.

No Professional Relationship. Reading this guide does not create an attorney-client, financial advisor-client, or any other professional relationship between you and SpectrumReady.

Time-Sensitive Information. Government benefit amounts, income thresholds, and program eligibility rules change regularly. Dollar figures and thresholds in this guide reflect information as of 2025. Always verify current amounts and rules directly with the relevant federal or state agency before making any decisions.

Individual Circumstances Vary. Eligibility for the programs discussed depends on your individual circumstances. This guide describes how programs generally work — not whether you or your child specifically qualifies.

Consult Professionals. For decisions about your child's specific situation — including SSI applications, IEP disputes, insurance appeals, or estate planning — consult a qualified special education attorney, disability benefits counselor, or other licensed professional.

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Welcome

If you're reading this, you're already doing something most parents don't: you're seeking out the information your child needs to thrive.

The programs in this guide are funded by federal and state governments — specifically to help families like yours. No one is required to tell you about them. Many families spend years missing out simply because they never knew to ask.

This guide changes that.

YOUR NEXT STEP AFTER READING

The most impactful action you can take this week: **Call your state's Developmental Disabilities agency and ask to be placed on the HCBS Medicaid waiver waiting list.** Waiting lists can be 5–10 years. Every day you wait is a day lost.

Program #1: Supplemental Security Income (SSI)

Up to \$943/Month — Plus Medicaid Coverage

SSI is a federal cash benefit from the Social Security Administration for children with disabilities whose family income falls below a certain threshold.

Key Fact	Detail
Monthly benefit	Up to \$943/month (2024)
Bonus	Automatically triggers Medicaid in most states
Age-18 rule	Parental income no longer counted — apply at 18 regardless of prior denial
How to apply	SSA.gov or call 1-800-772-1213

IF YOU'RE DENIED

~60% of initial claims are denied. ~60% of appeals are won. You have 60 days to appeal. Do not give up after the first denial.

Program #2: HCBS Medicaid Waiver

\$20,000–\$80,000+ Per Year in Services

Home and Community Based Services waivers fund intensive support that traditional Medicaid doesn't cover: respite care, day programs, supported employment, home modifications, assistive technology, and more.

WAITING LISTS ARE LONG — ACT NOW

Most states have HCBS waiver waiting lists of **5–10+ years**. The families who get services are the ones who got in line earliest. Call your state's Developmental Disabilities agency today and ask to be placed on the waiting list.

How to find your state's agency: Search "[Your State] developmental disabilities agency" or dial 2-1-1.

Program #3: IDEA — Free School Services

Federally Mandated, 100% Free to Your Family

Under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act, your child between ages 3 and 21 is entitled to a Free Appropriate Public Education with all needed special education services — at no cost to you.

Service	Covered?
ABA therapy through school	Yes — if educationally necessary
Speech-Language Therapy	Yes
Occupational Therapy	Yes
Physical Therapy	Yes
Transportation	Yes
Assistive Technology (AAC)	Yes

For children 0–3: Call your state's Early Intervention program — similar free services are available for infants and toddlers.

Your right: You can request a free special education evaluation from your school district at any time, in writing.

Program #4: ABLÉ Accounts

Save Up to \$100,000 Without Losing Benefits

The ABLÉ Act created tax-advantaged savings accounts for people with disabilities. For autism families, this is one of the most powerful financial tools available.

Feature	Details
SSI-protected savings	Up to \$100,000 — invisible to SSI
Annual contributions	Up to \$18,000/year from all sources
Who can contribute	Family, friends, anyone — not just the person with disability
How to open	ABLENRC.org — takes about 15 minutes

SMART MOVE

Ask grandparents and relatives to contribute to the ABLE account instead of giving cash gifts.
Over 18 years at \$200/month = \$43,000+ before any investment growth.

Program #5: Insurance Coverage for ABA Therapy

All 50 States Require It — Here's How to Get It

All 50 states have passed autism insurance reform laws requiring most health insurance plans to cover ABA therapy and other autism treatments. Your insurer cannot categorically refuse coverage.

Therapy	Typical Monthly Value
ABA Therapy (20–40 hrs/wk)	\$5,000–\$15,000
Speech Therapy (3x/wk)	\$600–\$1,200
Occupational Therapy (2x/wk)	\$400–\$800

If your insurer denies coverage: You have the right to appeal — through internal appeal, then external independent review. The companion guide "The Autism Insurance Battle Guide" covers the complete 4-level appeal process with exact scripts.

What to Do Next — Your Action List

- ☐ TODAY: Call your state's DD agency — get on the HCBS waiver waiting list
- ☐ THIS WEEK: Check SSI eligibility at SSA.gov or call 1-800-772-1213
- ☐ THIS WEEK: Open an ABLE account at ABLENRC.org (15 minutes)
- ☐ THIS MONTH: Contact your school district about special education services
- ☐ THIS MONTH: Call your insurance company — confirm ABA therapy coverage

WANT TO GO DEEPER?

This free guide is just the beginning. Our full **Autism Benefits Navigator (\$47)** covers every program in step-by-step detail. The **Complete Autism Parent Toolkit (\$127)** includes all 6 guides — benefits, IEPs, therapies, insurance, diagnosis, and transition planning. Visit **spectrumready.com** to see everything.

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Empowering autism families with the knowledge they deserve.

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This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute legal, financial, or medical advice. Program rules and benefit amounts are subject to change — verify current information with the relevant agency. For complex situations, consult a qualified professional.

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